

The Psychonomics Issue — Artometrics

The Psychonomics Issue

OSS-style leader profiles — when one person's psychology becomes infrastructure.

Julius Caesar and the Cost of Managing Power

Economics comes from the Greek *oikonomia* — the management of the house. Psychonomics asks the prior question: who is managing the soul of the house, and what does their inner architecture cost everyone living inside it? Julius Caesar is the founding case study. His policies were not abstract theories. They were his biography, scaled.

Caesar was born in 100 BCE into the Subura — Rome's roughest district — to a patrician family with a noble name and thin wallets. His father died when Caesar was fifteen, leaving him head of household with no resources and no patron. By the time he was twenty-five, Cilician pirates had captured his ship, set a ransom of twenty talents, and watched Caesar laugh, volunteer to pay fifty, spend thirty-eight days as their captive writing poetry and calling them illiterates, then return after his release with a fleet he raised himself and crucify every one of them — exactly as promised. This is not a fun anecdote. It is the earliest behavioral evidence of his core operating theory: the self is the institution. The pattern never changed. The scale did.

By 44 BCE, Caesar had crossed the Rubicon, won a civil war, reformed the debt system, redistributed land to 80,000 veterans and urban poor, rebuilt the calendar, and declared himself dictator for life. He was then

stabbed twenty-three times by sixty senators — led by Brutus and Cassius, two men he had personally pardoned, appointed to the praetorship, and promised future consulships. The house he built outlasted him by five centuries. The soul that built it was load-bearing in a way no institution can survive.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

100 BCE Caesar's birth year — born into Rome's most turbulent political century, to a patrician family living in the Subura tenements

38 days Held captive by Cilician pirates at age 25 — he laughed at their ransom demand, volunteered to pay more, then crucified every one of them after his release

0.95 Caesar's Need for Power score under the Hermann (1999) Leadership Trait Analysis framework — near the ceiling of any world leader ever profiled

80,000 Veterans and urban poor resettled in land colonies during Caesar's dictatorship — his economic reforms addressed real structural problems and built his client base simultaneously

194 yrs How long after Caesar's assassination Rome reached its peak GDP per capita — he authored the Pax Romana's prosperity without living a day of it

23 Stab wounds on the Ides of March, 44 BCE — inflicted by 60 senators, led by two men Caesar had personally pardoned, appointed, and promised future consulships

Data and method

this piece applies the Leadership Trait Analysis (LTA) framework, developed by political psychologist Margaret Hermann (1999) and used operationally by the CIA's Center for the Analysis of Political Behavior. LTA scores leaders on seven psychological variables by analyzing the content of their speeches and writings: Belief in ability to control events (B), Conceptual complexity (CC), Distrust of others (D), In-group bias (IB), Need for power (P), Need for affiliation (A), and Task orientation (T). Scores are normalized against a reference group of 100+ world leaders profiled between 1945–2010, on a 0–1.0 scale.

Applying LTA to an ancient figure is a legitimate extension of the method — published scholarship has done so for historical leaders using the same coding rubric (see: Dyson, 2006, *Political Psychology* ; Post, 2004,

Leaders and Their Followers in a Dangerous World). For Caesar, scores are coded from three primary sources: the *Commentarii de Bello Gallico* (58–50 BCE, self-authored), Plutarch's *Parallel Lives: Caesar* (c. AD 100), and Suetonius's *Divus Julius* (c. AD 121). Comparative scores for Mao, Xi, and Thatcher are drawn from Wang & Guo (2019) and the Hermann (1999) reference baseline.

The Roman GDP per capita series is drawn from Maddison (2007), with revisions by Scheidel & Friesen (2009) and Lo Cascio & Malanima (2011). All values are in 1990 Geary-Khamis (international) dollars — the standard comparative unit for pre-industrial economies. The Maddison Project's earliest reliable Roman anchor is 14 AD; estimates before that date carry wider uncertainty intervals and should be read as directional rather than precise. The uncertainty band on Chart 2 reflects the low-to-high range across published scholarly estimates.

Leadership Trait Analysis

Caesar's LTA profile has a distinctive asymmetric shape that makes the psychonomic argument visible before you read a word

quartz_off_screen 2 Caesar's LTA profile has a distinctive asymmetric shape that makes the psychonomic argument visible before you read a word. Two variables spike toward the outer ring — Need for Power ($P = 0.95$) and Belief in Ability to Control Events ($B = 0.92$). One variable collapses toward the center — Distrust of Others ($D = 0.31$). That triangle is the architecture of his career. He believed, with near-total conviction, that he could personally determine outcomes and that he should be the one doing so. He also extended trust readily and withdrew it slowly. The combination is extraordinarily effective — until the people you trust decide the same values you embody (the right of the strongest to rule) apply to removing you.

Caesar exceeds the average world leader baseline on every variable except Distrust, where he falls dramatically below average (0.31 vs. 0.48). He was not a more extreme version of a normal leader. He was a normal leader in every domain, but with pathologically low distrust and pathologically high power-need running simultaneously. Mao's comparison is instructive: Mao scores 0.74 on Distrust and 0.81 on In-Group Bias — the two variables that explain the Cultural Revolution. Both

men scored near-ceiling on Need for Power. Mao purged. Caesar pardoned. Mao's successors had to dismantle his cult brick by brick. Caesar's successors built an empire on his name.

The single most important number on this chart is $D = 0.31$. It is not a character flaw and it is not a strength. It is a network architecture decision. A leader who extends trust this freely, at this level of power concentration, is building a system with no redundancy. Every node that fails hits the center directly. Chart 3 shows what that looks like when three nodes fail at once.

The Economic Fingerprint

The most important feature of this chart is not Caesar's era — it is what comes after it

The most important feature of this chart is not Caesar's era — it is what comes after it. Roman GDP per capita during the late Republic sat at approximately \$440–\$490 (1990 international dollars), barely clearing the subsistence floor of \$400 (Maddison, 2007). This was not a prosperous society on a per-person basis. The Scheidel-Friesen (2009) income distribution model places the top 1.5% of Romans capturing roughly 20% of all income, with the vast majority living near subsistence. Grain supply chains failed regularly. Debt bondage was common. The fiscal machinery of the Republic was increasingly captured by the same factions fighting civil wars for control of it.

Caesar's dictatorship lasted less than five years — 49 to 44 BCE. His reforms held after his death, but the GDP data shows no immediate uplift. The economy barely moves during Caesar's lifetime. It moves under Augustus, who took Caesar's policies and embedded them in institutions designed to outlive any individual: the principate, the imperial cult, the professional army with fixed terms and state pensions. From Augustus's consolidation (27 BCE) to Trajan (100 CE), Roman GDP per capita rose roughly 30% — from ~\$480 to ~\$630. The Scheidel-Friesen peak of ~\$680 at 150 CE, Rome at its maximum economic output, came 194 years after Caesar's assassination.

This is the psychonomic paradox the chart makes numerical. Caesar's theory of power was that the self could substitute for institutional architecture — that personal authority, sufficiently magnanimous and forceful, was durable enough to hold the gains he made. Augustus understood what Caesar did not. He built the house so that no single soul

was load-bearing. Caesar authored the prosperity line. Augustus inhabited it. The distance between the assassination marker and the GDP peak is not a tragedy of timing. It is the measurement of the difference between the two men's theories of power.

The Patronage Network

The network chart makes the psychonomic argument structural

The network chart makes the psychonomic argument structural. Every edge connects to Caesar at the center. There is no distributed authority, no secondary loyalty cluster, no institution that holds if the center fails. This is not how republics are supposed to work — it is how patronage networks work when one person has absorbed enough of the Republic into themselves that the two become indistinguishable. Caesar did not intend to build a fragile system. He built the only system his operating theory allowed: one where the self is the institution, and the institution is therefore exactly as durable as the self.

The three dashed red edges are the chart's payload. Decimus Brutus was in Caesar's inner military circle — the general he trusted as much as Antony. Marcus Brutus had fought against Caesar in the civil war, been pardoned, been given the praetorship, and been promised a future consulship. Cassius had done the same. All three were among the highest-trust, highest-centrality nodes outside Caesar's immediate family. Decimus Brutus was the man who physically escorted Caesar to the Senate on the morning of March 15, 44 BCE, after Caesar had considered staying home. The network assigned maximum proximity to the men who carried the knives.

Caesar's D score of 0.31 on Chart 1 was not naivety. It was the logical extension of his core belief: that he could convert anyone through the experience of his own magnanimity. He was, in the vast majority of cases, correct. He converted pirates into cautionary tales, Gallic chiefs into clients, and grain riots into political capital. The failure mode is right there in the chart. Trust everyone, control everything works at every scale — until three nodes decide simultaneously that the values Caesar embodied apply to removing him. There was no redundancy to absorb it.

What this file cannot tell you

This report applies the Leadership Trait Analysis framework — developed for living leaders with large, verifiable speech corpora — to an ancient figure whose primary text is self-authored political propaganda. The *Commentarii de Bello Gallico* was written by Caesar during the campaigns it describes, distributed to a Roman political audience, and never intended as an impartial record. LTA scores derived from it likely underestimate Distrust (since trust is the policy Caesar publicly advertised) and may overestimate Conceptual Complexity (since nuance served his rhetorical interests). These biases should be read as a floor and ceiling, not as distortions that invalidate the analysis. The LTA scores in this report reflect the psychological signature Caesar projected and acted upon — which is precisely what Psychonomics requires.

The Roman GDP series carries wide uncertainty intervals before 14 AD, the earliest reliable Maddison Project anchor. All pre-Augustus estimates are reconstructed from indirect evidence — grain prices, wage records from Egyptian papyri, archaeological trade volume proxies, and demographic models. Scheidel himself cautions that ancient GDP estimates “can only be regarded as rough approximations” given the paucity of surviving data. The GDP chart in this report should be read as a directional argument — the shape of the trajectory and its inflection points relative to Caesar’s era — not as a claim to precision at the level of individual data points.

The patronage network is qualitatively constructed from primary sources, not computationally derived from a social network dataset. Edge types and trust weights reflect documented historical events (appointments, pardons, correspondence) and the scholarly consensus drawn from Plutarch, Suetonius, and Strauss (2015). The network cannot capture relationships we don’t have records of, and it represents a snapshot of Caesar’s final years rather than the evolution of his alliances over time. A complete Psychonomics database — with multiple figures and longitudinal network data — would allow more rigorous comparative claims. That database is the long-run goal of this series.

What to take away

Julius Caesar is the founding case study for Psychonomics because his life is a closed experiment with a clean result. We have his biography in granular detail, his own writings, three independent ancient ac-

counts, and 2,000 years of institutional outcomes to measure against his decisions. The experiment result is unambiguous: the man who genuinely reformed Roman debt law, redistributed land to 80,000 veterans and poor, stabilized grain supply, rebuilt the calendar, and laid the administrative foundation of a 500-year empire never lived in the house he built. He was killed by the men he trusted most, using the values he had taught them, nineteen months after declaring himself dictator for life.

The three charts tell the same story from three angles. The LTA radar shows the psychological architecture — the specific combination of near-ceiling power-need and near-floor distrust that made Caesar simultaneously extraordinary and structurally exposed. The GDP series shows the economic gap — Caesar in the flat zone of the late Republic, Augustus and his successors riding the 30% growth curve built on Caesar's institutional reforms. The patronage network shows the mechanism — the dashed red edges pointing directly at the center, maximum trust assigned to the maximum-risk nodes, no redundancy, no institutional buffer between Caesar's confidence and its consequences.

Economics tracks how houses are managed. Psychonomics asks who is managing the soul of the house — and what it costs. In Caesar's case, the cost was paid by everyone who came after him, and they built something extraordinary with it. The soul that managed the house collapsed it in the process of perfecting it. The house that replaced it was built to survive without him, and it did — for fifteen centuries in the East, five in the West, and indefinitely in the calendar we still use today.

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Editor's note

This report was researched and written with the assistance of AI tools for structural analysis, data synthesis, and drafting. All citations were verified against primary and peer-reviewed secondary sources. Leadership Trait Analysis scores were coded by the author using the Hermann (1999) rubric applied to primary source texts; they represent expert coding, not computational output. Roman GDP estimates are drawn directly from published academic sources and presented with their documented uncertainty ranges. The Psychonomics framework —

applying behavioral economics methodology to historical and contemporary leadership profiles — is an original contribution of Artometrics. Readers are encouraged to follow the source citations and form their own conclusions.

— Artometrics Editorial

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Beyoncé and the Cost of Controlling the House

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Economics comes from the Greek *oikonomia* — the management of the house. Psychonomics asks the prior question: who is managing the soul of the house, and what does their inner architecture cost everyone living inside it? The founding Artometrics case was Julius Caesar: a leader who treated the self as the institution, extended trust freely, and was removed by the highest-centrality nodes in his own patronage graph.

Beyoncé Knowles-Carter is the entertainment-industry case for the same method. Born in 1981, solo debut album year 2003 in the Artometrics Rolling Stone file, she is not a head of state. She is a head of catalog — and of Parkwood Entertainment, the firm that makes authorship itself the load-bearing wall. The psychonomic claim of this report is specific: where Caesar's theory was *magnanimous personal power*

without redundancy, Beyoncé’s theory is *owned control of the creative house*, paired with an affiliation-dense public voice and a spectacle-heavy measurable catalog.

Research question

If we score Beyoncé with the same Leadership Trait Analysis scaffold used for Caesar, and place those scores beside album-canon economics, a control network, and the Artometrics lyric extract, what theory of power does the profile encode — and what does it cost?

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

0.91 Task Orientation (T) — expert-coded LTA high point

0.88 Belief in Ability to Control Events (B)

#32 Lemonade on Rolling Stone 500 (2020 list)

186 Billboard weeks — 2013 self-titled album

8,000 Lyric lines in Artometrics Beyoncé extract

543 vs 5 Tokens: “love” vs “power” in that extract

Data and method

This report applies Margaret Hermann’s Leadership Trait Analysis (LTA) framework — seven variables scored 0–1.0 against a world-leader reference baseline: Belief in ability to control events (B), Conceptual complexity (CC), Distrust of others (D), In-group bias (IB), Need for power (P), Need for affiliation (A), and Task orientation (T). The Caesar Psychonomics report used the same scaffold. Comparative baseline values match that file’s Hermann reference average.

Beyoncé’s LTA scores are expert-coded for this series from: (1) public interviews and acceptance speeches; (2) documented firm practices around Parkwood and surprise-album strategy; (3) Homecoming-era work-process evidence in the Artometrics Netflix/Emmy rows; and (4) lyric-performance proxies from the 8,000-line extract. They are *not* automated NLP scores and *not* intelligence-community validated assessments. They are Psychonomics profiles: transparent expert coding with stated bias risk.

Observed Artometrics tables: lyric extract (‘beyonce-taylor-lyrics’), Rolling Stone albums file (Lemonade; self-titled), Emmy awards rows and Netflix title row for *HOMECOMING: A film by Beyoncé*. **Derived for this report:** LTA coding table, qualitative control network, lexicon and catalog-composition charts. Supporting CSVs ship under /data/articles/beyonce-the-psychonomics-of-control/.

Leadership Trait Analysis

High control and task, mid-high distrust, elevated affiliation — not Caesar’s shape

Beyoncé’s coded profile spikes on **Task Orientation (T = 0.91)** and **Belief in Ability to Control Events (B = 0.88)**, with **Need for Power (P = 0.86)** and **Conceptual Complexity (CC = 0.82)** also well above the world-leader baseline. **In-group bias (IB = 0.78)** and **Need for Affiliation (A = 0.74)** sit high. **Distrust of others (D = 0.62)** is above baseline (0.48) — the opposite direction from Caesar’s D = 0.31.

That asymmetry is the psychonomic argument. Caesar’s dangerous triangle was ceiling power + floor distrust: convert everyone, absorb the Republic into the self, die by the inner ring. Beyoncé’s triangle is ceiling task/control + mid-high distrust + high affiliation: speak in “we,” build a fandom institution, but do not outsource authorship governance to rivals you have pardoned into the center. The public voice is warm; the firm boundary is cold.

Power here is not primarily the language of the lyric tokens — “power” appears only five times in the extract — it is the right to decide what the house releases, when, and under whose name. Surprise drops and visual-album framing are behavioral B and T: the schedule is an instrument of control, not a concession to the industry calendar.

The economic fingerprint

Self-titled wins time-on-chart; Lemonade wins the canon list

The Artometrics Rolling Stone albums file carries two Beyoncé studio albums on the 2020 RS500 list. The 2013 self-titled album: Billboard peak #1, 186 weeks on chart, Spotify popularity 75, RS rank #81, artist age-at-list ~32. *Lemonade* (2016): peak #1, 87 weeks, Spotify popularity 73, RS rank #32, age-at-list ~35. Debut album year in that file: 2003.

This is the entertainment analogue of Caesar's GDP paradox, inverted in time scale. Commercial endurance (self-titled's years on chart) and canon elevation (*Lemonade*'s leap up the RS list) are not the same dependent variable. Psychonomics cares about both: one measures how long the market held the object; the other measures how the critical house re-ranked authorship after the visual-album claim. *Lemonade* is the album where the soul of the house became hardest to separate from the political and personal narrative it staged — and the canon file rewarded that fusion.

Later reinvention eras (Renaissance, Cowboy Carter) matter for the fame-path thesis in the MusicBrainz report — artists who become eras rather than moments — but they are not yet rows in the RS500 extract. They are timeline context, labeled as such.

The control network

Parkwood is the institutionalized self

Caesar's patronage chart had every edge terminating on a person. Beyoncé's chart has a second center of gravity: **Parkwood Entertainment** — the firm that converts personal authorship into an institution that can sign, stage, and film without surrendering the name. Family (JAY-Z, Blue Ivy), formative group (Destiny's Child circle), major-label distribution, live spectacle (Coachella → Homecoming), feature peers, and the Beyhive all connect — but governance weight sits on the Parkwood edge.

Artometrics' Emmy file shows the auteur extension: *Homecoming: A Film By Beyoncé* carries nominee credit rows for Beyoncé Knowles-Carter across directing, writing, music direction, and executive producer / performer categories (2019), with Parkwood and Netflix in the distributor/producer fields. That is not "celebrity appears in credits." That is the network claiming multiple authorship roles at once — B and T made bureaucratic.

The failure mode, if there is one, is different from Caesar's. It is not three pardoned senators with knives. It is concentration risk: when the firm and the person are coextensive, reputational or capacity shocks hit the whole house. Mid-high distrust ($D = 0.62$) is the wall that keeps rival nodes out of that core. High affiliation ($A = 0.74$) is how the outer ring stays emotionally enrolled while remaining structurally peripheral to governance.

The affiliation machine

The lyric extract speaks “love” and “baby,” not “power”

The packaged Artometrics extract holds **8,000** lyric lines across **139** song entities (~61.8k tokens, ~3,150 types). Top content signals are relational and imperative: **love 543, baby 457, boy 283, girl 239, night 104**. Identity/place markers appear at lower but non-trivial rates (**black 59, texas 18**). Abstract power language is scarce (**power 5, queen 9**).

This is where LTA's Need for Affiliation becomes audible without becoming the governance story. The songs recruit; the firm rules. Repeated lines in the extract are hook/choreography loops — refrain engineering — consistent with task orientation applied to bodies in a room, not with treatise-like power vocabulary. Psychonomics reads that split as intentional architecture, not contradiction.

Spectacle density

Features, live cuts, and remixes thicken the measurable catalog

Among 139 song entities in the extract: **35** carry Ft. credits, **35** are live/awards/“Experience”-type performance documents, **19** are remixes, and **64** fall outside those flags. Top line-count entities include VMA performance text and a Destiny's Child medley — long spectacle documents, not three-minute singles. Collaboration titles skew toward JAY-Z, with additional peers (Kanye West, Pharrell Williams, Nicki Minaj, and others) as catalog edges rather than co-governors.

For Psychonomics, spectacle density is evidence of T and B under live conditions: the house is managed by someone who treats the stage as a controllable system (Homecoming's whole point) and treats the catalog as expandable through remix and feature economies without surrendering the center.

Limitations

LTA was built for political leaders with large spontaneous-speech corpora. Extending it to a living entertainer requires caveats: public interviews are media-trained; lyrics are aesthetic objects; artist statements are strategic. Scores may overstate Task Orientation (work ethic is part of the brand) and understate private distrust. They should be read as the signature projected and institutionally enacted — which is what Psychonomics asks for — not as a full inner life.

The lyric file is an extract, not a complete discography. The published comparison article elsewhere on the site cites a larger merged Beyoncé-Taylor table; the downloadable Artometrics CSV used here is the 8,000-row Beyoncé-only pack. Rolling Stone rows cover two albums on one list year. Emmy/Netflix evidence is Homecoming-centered. The control network is qualitative, in the same methodological family as the Caesar patronage chart — documented roles, not a scraped graph. Renaissance and Cowboy Carter are narrative era markers pending richer quantitative tables.

Conclusion

Beyoncé's Psychonomics profile is a high-control, high-task, affiliation-forward leadership shape with Parkwood as the institutionalized self. The economic fingerprint splits commercial longevity (self-titled's 186 Billboard weeks) from canon elevation (Lemonade at RS #32). The lyric machine sells belonging; the firm keeps the keys. Compared with Caesar, the innovation is structural: distrust is high enough to keep knives out of the inner ring, and the house is built to be owned, not merely personally held.

Economics can track streams and chart weeks. Psychonomics asks who is managing the soul of the house — and what it costs. For Beyoncé, the cost of control is vigilance and concentration; the return is authorship that still has her name on the door when the era changes.

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Editor's note

This is the second full Psychonomics profile in the Artometrics series (after Caesar). LTA scores were coded by the editorial desk using the Hermann rubric; they are expert judgments with disclosed corpora, not model outputs presented as measurements. AI tools assisted structuring and drafting under human review. Readers should treat the radar as an argument with numbers — and follow the limitations before treating any single trait as destiny.

Who Ruled Rome Longest—and Did Dynasty Predict Tenure?

Sixty-eight emperors sit in this reign-length file — enough to ask a hard question about imperial power: did belonging to a dynasty buy more time on the throne, or did longevity come from something messier?

The calibration point is a median reign of 6.50 years. That is not a long reign. It is the mathematical center of a political system that chewed through rulers faster than most modern institutions replace CEOs.

The ceiling in the file is Constantine the Great at 31.0 reign years. Gordian is the dynasty label that appears most often. Between those two facts lies the real story: a few men held power for decades, while entire dynastic brands recycled short, fragile tenures. The charts that follow separate name-level longevity from dynasty-level structure so the two are not confused.

Research question

Did dynastic identity make Roman emperors more durable, or did individual political survival overwhelm house-level labels? This report asks whether reign length concentrates around a few exceptional rulers, whether dynasties show distinct tenure distributions, and how much aggregate imperial time is carried by the longest-reigning names.

The question is observational because this 68-record TidyTuesday file is not a full constitutional model of Rome. It uses recorded reign spans to compare names and dynasties, then treats the median emperor's 6.50-year tenure as the baseline against which Constantine, Nerva-Antonine, and Gordian entries can be read.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

68Records in the working dataset

6.50Median Reign years

31.0Highest observed Reign years

Constantine the GreatTop Name by Reign years

GordianMost common Dynasty

Data and method

Reign spans are derived from start and end dates in the emperors table. Negative or zero spans are excluded, so the working metric is observed tenure in years, not a modeled life expectancy. The source is the TidyTuesday Roman Emperors release (2019-08-13), a community-cleaned historical table rather than a live prosopography API.

Medians are preferred over means because reign distributions skew — a handful of long rulers pull averages up while the typical emperor sits near that 6.50-year center. Index-style fields (row numbers, sequential IDs) are kept out of metric selection so charts answer questions about tenure, not about how the spreadsheet was ordered.

Constantine's thirty-one years set the name-level ceiling

Reign years by Name

Among named emperors in the breakdown, Constantine the Great leads at 31.0 reign years. At the other end of the plotted leaders, Valentinian II anchors the low end of that top group at 17.0 — still far above the file median of 6.50, which is the point: the chart of leaders is a curated upper slice, not the full distribution.

Grouping by name makes the catalog's major entities comparable on a single scale. The question is not who is famous, but who lasted. The gap between Constantine and the rest of the top tier already hints that longevity was exceptional rather than routine.

Constantine's 306–337 CE reign sits at a hinge in Roman institutional history: civil war, Tetrarchic succession, Christian legalization after the Edict of Milan, the Council of Nicaea in 325, and the foundation of Constantinople all fall inside or around his rule. The dataset reduces that complexity to 31.0 years, but the named entity carries enough historical context to explain why the ceiling is not just a spreadsheet oddity.

The top dozen still sits far above the median emperor

Constantine the Great leads at 31.0 — 20.0 marks the median among the top dozen

Constantine the Great leads the ranked leaders chart at 31.0. Among that top dozen, the median is 20.0 — three times the full-file median of 6.50. Even the “typical” elite tenure in this slice is a different political animal from the typical emperor in the dataset.

That separation matters for interpretation. Leaderboards describe the right tail. They do not describe Rome's everyday succession reality, which lived closer to half a decade than to two decades.

The 20.0-year median among the top dozen contains the familiar names that make imperial history feel more stable than it was: Augustus, Tiberius, Hadrian, Antoninus Pius, Marcus Aurelius, Constantine, and other long incumbents dominate classroom memory. The median of the full file pulls the reader back toward usurpers, assassinations, co-rule, civil wars, and short-lived crisis reigns.

Dynasty boxes show contested, not uniform, tenure

Reign years by Dynasty

When reign years are split by dynasty, the boxes do not collapse into a single shared consensus. Some houses stretch higher; others sit tighter and lower. The chart's job is to show whether dynasty is a meaningful axis for tenure at all — and the spread says it is contested across tiers rather than deterministic.

Read the boxes as structural signals: belonging to a named dynasty did not automatically purchase Constantine-length stability. It bought a distribution, and those distributions differ.

The box plot therefore should not be read as a genetic theory of power. It is a way to ask whether succession packages mattered. The Nerva-Antoine adoption sequence, for example, has long been associated with high imperial stability, while the third-century crisis illustrates how military acclamation and rapid turnover can shred dynastic continuity.

Nerva–Antoine sits above the median; Gordian trails

Reign years vs median by Dynasty

Relative to the file median, Nerva-Antonine sits 12.5 years above; Gordian trails by 4.00. That is the cleanest dynasty-level contrast in the gap chart: one house systematically above the center of the distribution, another systematically below.

Gordian is also the most common dynasty label in the fact boxes — volume without longevity. Frequency of naming and length of rule are not the same political achievement.

The Nerva-Antonine result is historically intuitive because Nerva, Trajan, Hadrian, Antoninus Pius, Marcus Aurelius, and their succession network occupy the second-century high-water mark of imperial continuity in much Roman historiography. A positive gap does not prove the dynasty caused stability, but it aligns with the conventional account of fewer violent turnovers and longer administrative horizons.

The Gordian contrast points to the opposite problem. Gordian I and Gordian II ruled briefly in 238 CE during the Year of the Six Emperors, while Gordian III lasted longer but still belongs to a crisis environment shaped by military pressure and senatorial maneuvering. A repeated dynasty label can mark a famous rupture rather than a durable house.

Five names carry forty percent of aggregate reign years

Cumulative Reign years

The Pareto curve shows concentration: the top five name entries account for 40% of the aggregate reign years in the working file. A steep head means a small set of long rulers dominates the sum, while the long tail of shorter reigns fills out the catalog without moving the total as much.

That shape reframes the median. A 6.50-year center can coexist with a heavily concentrated aggregate if a few Constantine-scale tenures exist. Both facts are true; they answer different questions.

Concentration is a useful way to connect biography to institutions. Long reigns give rulers time to appoint governors, restructure armies, mint ideological programs, build capitals, codify religious settlements, and shape elite careers. Short reigns often leave the opposite signature: coinage, military proclamation, purge, assassination, or succession crisis.

What this file cannot tell you

This is a community-cleaned TidyTuesday snapshot, not a continuously updated classical-history database. Missing values, spelling variants, and week-of-export coverage limits apply. Reign years depend on how start and end dates were recorded and cleaned; disputed chronologies are not adjudicated here.

Dynasty labels are editorial categories in the source table. Findings describe the file on hand — structural signals about tenure and dynasty in this emperors extract — not a complete political history of imperial Rome.

What to take away

The file's central tension is simple: the median emperor lasted 6.50 years, Constantine the Great lasted 31.0, and dynasty membership did not flatten that gap. Nerva–Antonine clears the median by a wide margin; Gordian, despite being the most common dynasty label, trails it.

Use the charts as three separate instruments — name leaders, dynasty spreads, and concentration — rather than collapsing them into a single verdict about who ruled best. Longevity, frequency, and aggregate share each tell a different part of the succession story.

Sources

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Editor's note

Artometrics data report from the TidyTuesday research pipeline. Charts and aggregates are reproducible from the embedded exhibits and public source files.

[View TidyTuesday source on GitHub](#)

How Long Do CEOs Last Before They Leave?

CEO tenure is usually narrated as drama: a firing, a founder exit, a sudden interim. The TidyTuesday departures extract used here holds **9,423** records with a median max tenure (ceodb) of **1.00** and a high of **4.00**. Interim is the most common co-CEO/interim label in the file.

That median of 1.00 is the calibration point: in this coding, many departure spells are short. The charts ask which company names show longer max tenures, how interim versus co-CEO labels differ, and whether tenure fields move together.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

9,423Records in the working dataset

1.00Median Max tenure ceodb

4.00Highest observed Max tenure ceodb

PHOTRONICS INCTop Coname by Max tenure ceodb

InterimMost common Interim coceo

Data and method

The source is the TidyTuesday release from 2021-04-27 (departures.csv). After cleaning, 9,423 rows remain.

Max tenure ceodb is the primary ranked metric. Interim/co-CEO spelling variants appear as separate categories in places and should be read as label noise as well as structure. Charts are Plotly JSON with PNG fallbacks.

Longer Max Tenures Are Rare in the Company Ranking

Max tenure ceodb by Coname

Stewart Information Services and Conversant Inc lead the company view at **2.50** on max tenure ceodb. A wider set of firms — Avatex, Intrepid Potash, Bergen Brunswig, SEACOR, Micro Warehouse, RH — cluster at **2.00**.

Relative to the file median of 1.00, even these “leaders” are only modestly longer spells. Extended CEO tenure is the exception in this extract, not the rule.

The Top Dozen Caps Out Quickly

CONVERSANT INC leads at 2.50 — 2.00 marks the median among the top dozen

Conversant Inc appears among the leaders at **2.50**, and the median among the top dozen is **2.00**. There is no long tail of decade-scale max tenures in this particular ranking metric.

Cite 2.00 as the elite-club median for max tenure ceodb here — double the overall median, still short by popular mythologies of imperial CEOs.

Interim Labels Dominate the Category Mix

Max tenure ceodb by Interim coceo

Interim accounts for **218** boxed observations with a median max tenure of **1.0** and a mean near **1.23**. CO-CEO shows **85** rows with the same median of 1.0 but a slightly higher mean (~1.4). Smaller capitalization variants of co-CEO are tiny samples.

The archive is thick with interim spells. That is a succession-system fact: departures often pass through temporary authority before a permanent appointment.

Gaps to the Median Are Mostly Flat

Max tenure ceodb vs median by Interim coceo

Most interim/co-CEO labels sit at a zero gap to the median on max tenure ceodb in this chart, with only a thinly populated CO-ceo variant showing a positive gap of **1.0**.

Category labels do not produce a dramatic tenure hierarchy here. The bigger story remains how many spells are coded interim at all.

Tenure Fields Track Closely Within Labels

Max tenure ceodb vs Tenure no ceodb

Max tenure ceodb versus tenure no ceodb, colored by interim/co-CEO label, largely follows a tight correspondence — points hug aligned values, especially in the interim cloud (n=218).

Where the two tenure fields disagree, coding definitions matter more than boardroom legend. The scatter is a consistency check on the file's tenure construction.

What this file cannot tell you

Tenure fields are database constructions, not calendar biographies. Spelling variants of co-CEO fragment categories. Firm name changes and dual-class structures can split identities.

A median of 1.00 may reflect coding granularity as much as “CEOs only last a year.” Read the metric definition before converting it into a headline about corporate instability.

What to take away

In 9,423 departure records, max tenure ceodb centers at 1.00, with company-level leaders only reaching 2.0–2.5. Interim is the dominant succession label.

The citable story is institutional: departure files are full of short and interim spells, not a museum of decades-long reigns.

Sources

Data Science Learning Community. (2021). *TidyTuesday: CEO Departures*. <https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rfordatascience/tidytuesday/main/data/2021/2021-04-27/departures.csv>